

FAST FORWARD A semi high-speed locomotive on the Sarkhej-Dholera double line

Takeaways

- **The Sarkhej-Dholera line—134 km long—will see speeds of 200 kmph**
- **The Special Investment Region at Dholera is now a beehive of activity**

it "a strong testament" to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision. The project's justification rests on the DSIR project coming to fruition as the flagship node on the Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor. "It is spread over 920 sq km, larger than Singapore at 736 sq km," says Kuldeep Arya, CEO and managing director, DSIR Development Authority.

The SIR is anchored by Tata Electronics' Rs 91,000 crore semiconductor fab, whose first chips are targeted for December 2026. Dutch lithography major ASML signed an MoU with Tata Electronics in May to supply equipment for the Dholera plant.

Around the fab, a broader industrial base is taking shape. The 4,400 MW Dholera Solar Park will draw in most majors; the EV side sees participation from, inter alia, Tsingshan Holding Group; Mahindra is developing a world city; and a silicon photonics unit by Jabil etches the state-of-the-art. Arya says talks with 40 more companies are in the pipeline, expected to be firmed up within a year and operational by end-2028.

This will begin to drive demand for residential, educational and healthcare infrastructure in the region. On cue, the six-lane Ahmedabad-Dholera Expressway is near completion, with 80 per cent of land acquisition done. Dholera International Airport is in Phase 1, with first flights expected by the end of this year.

AIRPORT TAKES FLIGHT

"Dholera will become Ahmedabad's primary airport in a few years. The existing one will not suffice. The way this region is coming up, it needs a high-speed railway line," Arya says. With Ahmedabad hosting the 2030 Commonwealth Games and bidding for the 2036 Olympics, Dholera is positioned to absorb the bulk of international traffic, aided by a geography that allows westbound routing via West Asia without overflying Pakistan.

The political geography is striking. Its most consolidated beneficiary is Shah's constituency. Gandhinagar already hosts the upcoming bullet train terminus, GIFT City, and the Narendra Modi Stadium—the world's largest cricket venue—along which the Sardar Patel Sports Enclave is coming up on the Sabarmati riverbank. With this project, it also becomes Point A for India's first semi high-speed rail line. ■

KERALA

White Paper Versus Red Economics

Satheesan sparks a debate on Kerala's fiscal mess with stark data, but critics ask what his alternative is

By **Jeemon Jacob**

KERALA'S FINANCES HAVE BEEN THE SUBJECT of a running argument between Thiruvananthapuram and New Delhi for a decade: the state accusing the Centre of starving its high welfare model, the latter warning about rising debt and "off budget" borrowing. With the Left now voted out, that argument has come home as the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) opens its innings with a contentious audit of the account books it has inherited. The V.D. Satheesan government, facing a daunting fiscal task ahead as it looks to realise its own welfare promises, has chosen to hold up its empty wallet for all to see.

On June 4, Satheeshan tabled a white paper on the state's finances in the assembly. What it spelt out promises to spur lasting academic and political debate: accumulated liabilities of Rs 5.07 lakh crore, a perilous 35.5 per cent of GSDP, far above the prescribed 'healthy limit' of 20 per cent. Also, arrears of Rs 48,733 crore.

Takeaways

- **UDF presents white paper on Kerala's fiscal crisis, arguing Left rule has left it with little to spare**
- **Critics cite the federal squeeze, floods, Covid; protests abort proposal to raise retirement age**